
Beginners Guide

to

Inbound Marketing

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THE BEGINNERS GUIDE TO INBOUND MARKETING

Chris Battis is an Inbound marketing professional and serial entrepreneur with over 10 years of experience in entrepreneurship, marketing, strategy development, and launching brands. Chris has always been on the cutting edge regarding all aspects of technology and online marketing, including: web development, search engine optimization, social media marketing, blogging, analytics, and any other technology he can lay his hands on.

He is best known for his dedication to developing creative inbound marketing campaigns that produce measurable results. Chris truly believes that any small business can leverage content marketing, search engine optimization and attractive website design to grow their business.

When he's not generating website traffic and converting leads, Chris can be found surfing the icy cold waters of New Hampshire or skiing the white stuff in the White Mountains.



Follow Chris on Twitter:
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Chapter One:

Inbound Marketing: The Basics

What's the difference between inbound and outbound marketing?

Inbound marketing is a newer marketing method that focuses on getting found by customers online. Inbound Marketing focuses on three principles; **getting found**, **converting leads**, and **analyzing your website traffic**.

Outbound marketing, once an effective way to reach target audiences, is now becoming a thing of the past. This type of marketing consists of cold calling, buying email lists to email blast, direct mail, TV commercials, radio commercials, and telemarketing.

What is considered Inbound Marketing?

- CMS Websites
- Blogging
- Social Media Marketing
- Search Engine Optimization (SEO)
- Premium Content (Ebooks, Whitepapers)
- Webinars
- Search Advertising
- Opt-In Email Marketing

What's considered Outbound Marketing?

- Print Advertisements
- TV Commercials
- Banner Ads
- Trade Shows
- Direct Mail
- Billboard Advertising

How Have Outbound Marketing Methods Become Less Effective?

The average consumer has become smarter and found advanced ways to block out unwanted messages, such as telemarketing, emails, and TV commercials. Consumers now have caller ID, spam filters, and DVR, which makes it harder for Outbound Marketing methods to work.

- 200 Million Americans have registered on the FTC's "Do Not Call" list
- 44% of direct mail is never opened
- 86% of people skip television ads

People Make Buying Decisions on the Internet.

90% of consumer buying decisions start on the web.

-Forrester Research, 2007

92% of online users first use search engines to look for products and services.

-HubSpot

71% of B2B buyers go to the Internet to get industry specific information.

-HubSpot

Almost 8 new people come onto the internet every second.

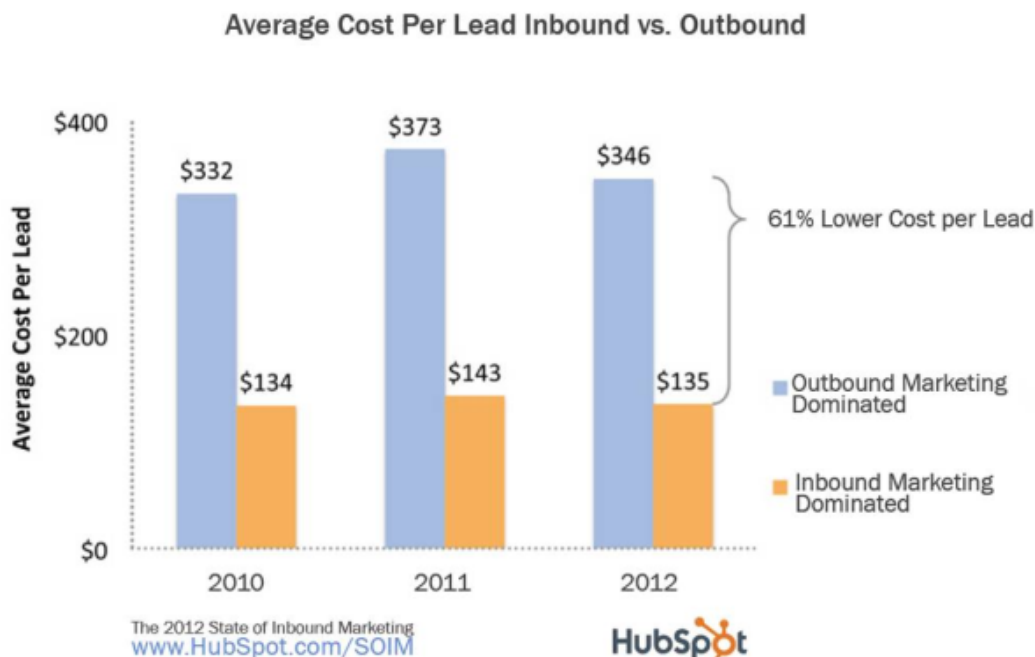
-HubSpot

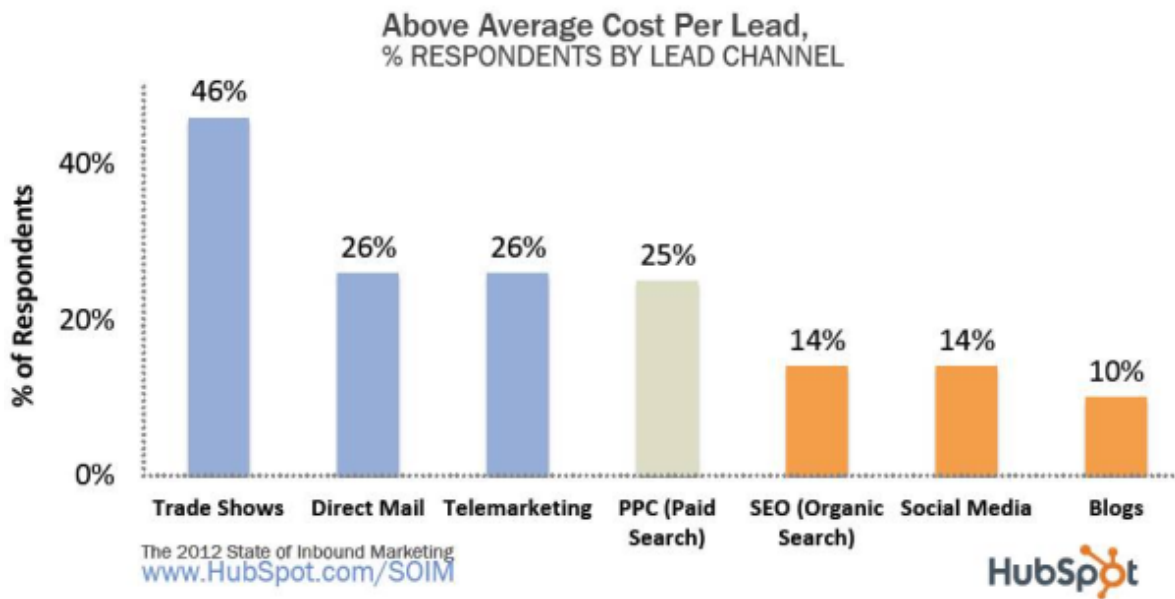
Inbound Marketing Has Caused Outbound Marketing Methods to Become Obsolete.

Effective tactics, including webinars, ebooks, blogs, opt-in email nurturing, and growing relationships through social media make up this new Inbound Marketing powerhouse.

Inbound marketing-dominated organizations experience a 61% lower cost per lead

-Hubspot, 2012.





Businesses Are Making The Switch To Inbound

89% of marketers are either maintaining or increasing their Inbound Marketing budgets.

The average budget spent on company blogs and social media has nearly tripled in three years.

In 2012, small businesses are only desogmating 14% of their budget to outbound marketing, while large businesses are allocating 33%.

81% of businesses rated their company blogs as “useful,” “important” or “critical.” An impressive 25% rated their company blog as “critical” to their business.

The difference between inbound and outbound marketing expenditures grew by 50% from 2011 to 2012.

Source: Survey by HubSpot, 2012 State of Inbound Marketing Report.

Chapter 2:

6 Inbound Marketing Pre-Requisites

Inbound Marketing, if properly executed, will increase traffic to your website and increase the number of leads for your business. Now don't run to your boss and ask for a raise just yet, you need to plan out your Inbound Marketing campaign first! Follow these six steps to ensure your company is a good fit for Inbound Marketing.

1. Who is in Charge? You need a team

Let's be honest here, Inbound Marketing is not a part-time job. From creating a lead generating website, to writing education content, maintaining and keeping up to date with the latest changes in search engine optimization, preparing video content, and optimizing landing pages, there is a lot to do! It's important to have a team that can complete all of these tasks on a daily basis.

Don't fret, not everyone can afford to hire an Inbound Marketing department. It is highly recommended that small businesses executing Inbound Marketing have at least one person assigned to the process. If that individual needs help with their campaign or needs resources that your business can't provide inhouse, they can receive support from an Inbound Marketing agency.

2. Assess Your Current Marketing Plan

A huge part of Inbound Marketing is analyzing traffic and results. Before you can start analyzing your Inbound Marketing efforts, you need to look at your current marketing plan. Take note of how much traffic you are receiving, how many of those visitors are converting to leads, and how many of these leads have become customers. Knowing this information will help you greatly with your new Inbound Marketing efforts.

3. Define Your Goals

Defining quantitative goals will allow you to successfully measure your success with Inbound Marketing. Want to increase website traffic? Great! How much and over what time span? How many leads or sales do you need a month? How many blogs will you need to write a month? What actions need to be taken to complete these goals? Asking yourself these questions will help you accurately plan your Inbound Marketing strategy.

4. Develop Your Company's Brand

This part of the process should be a team effort so that everyone involved knows exactly who you are as a company and how you define your brand identity. You also need to determine your company's goals. Make sure all your employees have a clear understanding of your brand and your goals.

5. Who is Your Target Audience?

Who are you trying to sell to? How does your target market differ among different demographics? Your company has a variety of people you are trying to sell to, but they are all different and need to be treated differently. You need to define your buyer personas, so you can determine how to sell to each persona.

Start with 2 or 3 buyer personas and build them out in full detail. You want to create each buyer persona to mimic an actual customer from each target audience. For example you can have a “marketing Mary” and an “owner Ollie”. The more detail about each persona the better! We also recommend displaying your buyer personas for all your employees to see. This will help everyone at the company understand your potential customers.

6. Create a Game Plan

Now that you are ready to get started, the key to Inbound Marketing success is to plan! You have determined WHAT needs to be done, now determine HOW it is going to be done. Breaking up the work into smaller goals and benchmarks month by month allows you to monitor the progress and stay motivated by achieving intermediate goals. The more detailed your game plan is, the easier it is for you to stay on track with your Inbound Marketing strategy.

Chapter 3:

Get Found Online

Getting found online is the first goal of Inbound Marketing. In order for your website to get found, you need to drive traffic to your site. Once you have the traffic, then you can convert leads and eventually customers.

In order for your website to obtain traffic and generate leads, it needs to be optimized. A fully optimized website requires several components that are essential to Inbound Marketing.

Blogging

Blogging is an important task to complete each week in order to drive traffic to your website. You want your blog to be consistent in terms of number of blogs per week and the style of writing. Like we said before, when you develop your brand, you also want to think about your company's voice. Blog content should be educational, thought provoking, unique, and relevant to your business and its target personas. A good place to start generating blog ideas is to compile a list of frequently asked questions from your customers and blog about each question. Chances are that if one person had that question, there are several potential customers who have the same question and they are looking for the answer!

Using the right tools, like HubSpot's blog management software, it is very simple to follow SEO best practices, schedule article, and review blog analytics. HubSpot takes the guesswork out of blogging and you can rest assured that all your hard work is fully optimized to maximize your results.

When blogging for your business, you want to constantly educate your potential customers. Your blog will soon become a source of relevant information related to your business. Potential customers will see you as an authority in your field and will ultimately gain trust in your company. When they are ready to buy, you will be the first company that comes to mind.

Search Engine Optimization

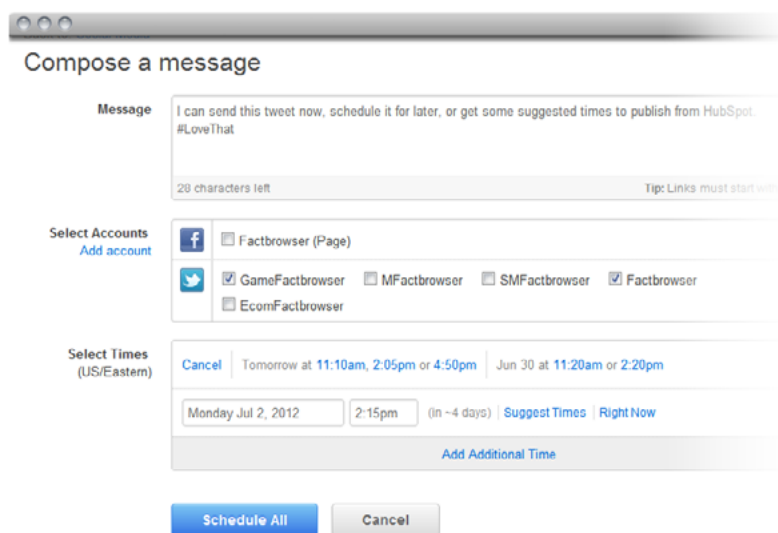
SEO prepares your website to be fully optimized for the search engines in order for you to rank for a set of keywords. This ever-changing process is a powerful tool to ensure that your business is visible online. HubSpot offers a variety of tools to **get you started with SEO** and help you track your success. If you are starting to optimize your website for the search engines, we recommend you use HubSpot's on-page SEO template.

Once you have your website pages SEO ready, you can analyze your efforts with HubSpot's page

performance tool. This tool keeps you informed if any of your pages are missing a SEO component and gives you tips on how to fix any issues.

Social Media Marketing

Social media is another great tool to help you get found online and drive traffic to your website. There are several social media platforms available, which can be overwhelming to most businesses trying to figure out where to start. The key to **social media marketing** is finding the social platforms that work best for your business. Recommended social platforms to start with are Facebook, Twitter, LinkedIn, and Google+.



The screenshot shows a web-based interface for composing and scheduling a social media message. At the top, it says "Compose a message". Below this is a "Message" section with a text input area containing the text "I can send this tweet now, schedule it for later, or get some suggested times to publish from HubSpot. #LoveThat". Below the text input is a character count "20 characters left" and a tip "Tip: Links must start with http://". Below the message section is a "Select Accounts" section with a sub-link "Add account". It lists several accounts: "Factbrowser (Page)" with an unchecked checkbox, "GameFactbrowser" with a checked checkbox, "MFactbrowser" with an unchecked checkbox, "SMFactbrowser" with an unchecked checkbox, "Factbrowser" with a checked checkbox, and "EcomFactbrowser" with an unchecked checkbox. Below the accounts section is a "Select Times (US/Eastern)" section. It shows a "Cancel" button and two time slots: "Tomorrow at 11:10am, 2:05pm or 4:50pm" and "Jun 30 at 11:20am or 2:20pm". Below these is a date and time selector showing "Monday Jul 2, 2012" and "2:15pm" (in ~4 days), with links for "Suggest Times" and "Right Now". Below the time selector is a link "Add Additional Time". At the bottom are two buttons: "Schedule All" and "Cancel".

You want to use these social media platforms to engage with visitors, customers, and fans. Social media allows you to improve your company's reputation and visibility online.

Social Media Advertising

Paid advertising on social media networks is also a great option to increase traffic to your website. Placing ads on different social media networks can increase your chances to reach millions of potential customers. The best part of **social media advertising** is the flexibility the price. You can choose how much you want to spend each month allowing this to fit into any budget.

Chapter 5:

Convert More Leads

Now that your website is fully optimized AND you are getting found online, you now have to focus on getting more leads. To be able to convert traffic into leads, you need to have an appealing website filled with calls-to-action, compelling offers, and landing pages.

An Offer They Can't Pass Up

The best way to convert traffic into leads is to create unique and appealing content offers for your visitors. This content comes in the form of free ebooks, whitepapers, videos, templates, and webinars. By creating irresistible content offers, you can dramatically increase your lead generation, which ultimately leads to more customers.

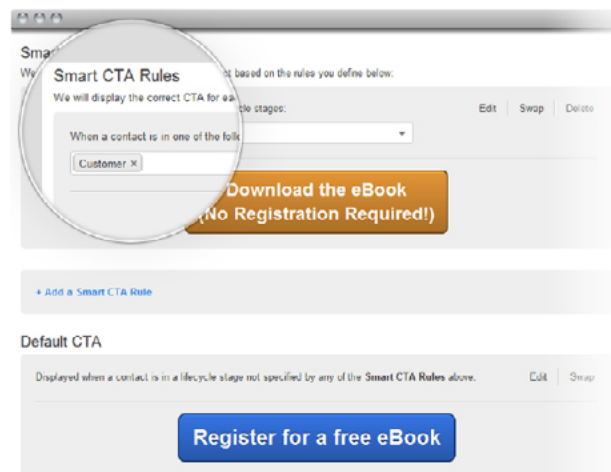
Landing Pages

Landing pages typically consist of a page describing an offer with a form for the visitor to fill out to download the offer. Once the visitor fills out the form, they are now a lead. If you think about it, landing pages are a crucial part of converting visitors to leads. The content on landing pages needs to entice the visitor to give you their information. The landing page should describe in a detailed, yet concise way exactly what the visitor will receive if they download the offer. Including a visually appealing graphic is also a great way to attract leads and keep them coming back for more offers.

Calls To Action

Calls to action (CTAs) and landing pages work together as a team to help you generate leads from traffic. Visually creative CTAs throughout your site are important to bring traffic to your landing pages. How does this all work you may ask?

While website visitors are browsing your site, they will come across **amazing graphically designed CTAs** that are creatively telling them how to take action. After clicking on the CTA, they are brought to a corresponding landing page. After they receive further information about the offer from the landing page, they fill out the form and become a lead. The more leads you generate, the more potential customers you have. Now you are getting it!



Chapter 6:

Get More Sales

After working hard to increase traffic to your site and generate leads, you now need to close the deal and convert those leads to customers! Proven techniques, such as lead nurturing and opt-in email marketing, will help you effectively pull your leads down the sales funnel into becoming a customer. Once the lead is at the bottom of the sales funnel, you can hand things over to your sales team to close the sale. It is important to note that marketing and sales should work together to constantly improve and implement new buyer personas in order to convert more leads.

Lead Nurturing

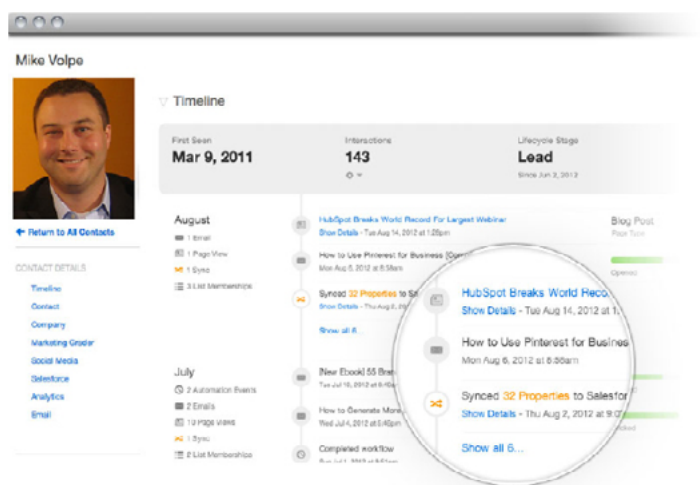
One of the biggest mistakes a business can make is forgetting about their leads and not properly nurturing them. You should focus on taking the proper steps to ensure your lead makes their way down the sales funnel in order to qualify them as sales ready.

When a visitor converts to a lead, they are categorized as a top-of-the-funnel lead. This means in order for them to become a bottom-of-the-funnel lead, you need to engage them in a lead nurturing campaign. This campaign will work them down the sales funnel by using email marketing best practices. You can create a campaign suited to their specific characteristics, making them more likely to use your company's solution or product.

Lead Intelligence

When it comes to generating leads and converting customers, knowledge is king. By using Inbound Marketing tools, you have the power to analyze every step you take. This provides you with knowledge about your visitors, leads, and customers, which gives you greater insight into how to execute your marketing plan.

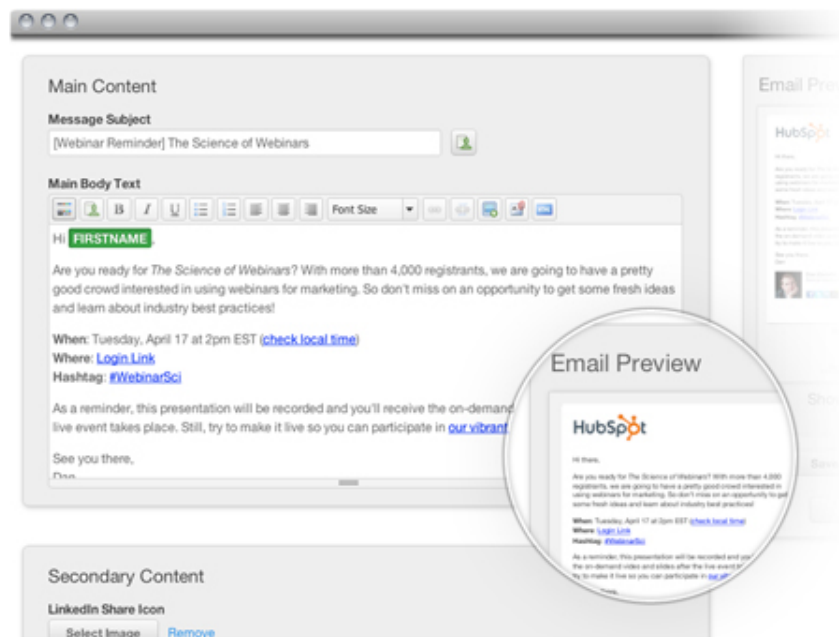
How did your leads find you? What content offers did they download? Which blog articles and pages did they find interesting? This valuable information allows you to nurture your leads effectively.



Email Marketing

You now know what content your leads are interested in, so keep sending it to them! The more interesting and relevant content you send to your leads, the more engaged they become with your company. When it is time to buy there is a higher chance that they will come to you.

Email marketing is essential to any Inbound Marketing program, especially when implemented using HubSpot's Best Practices for optimal lead nurturing. Email marketing is another way to communicate and build relationships with your leads.



Chapter 7:

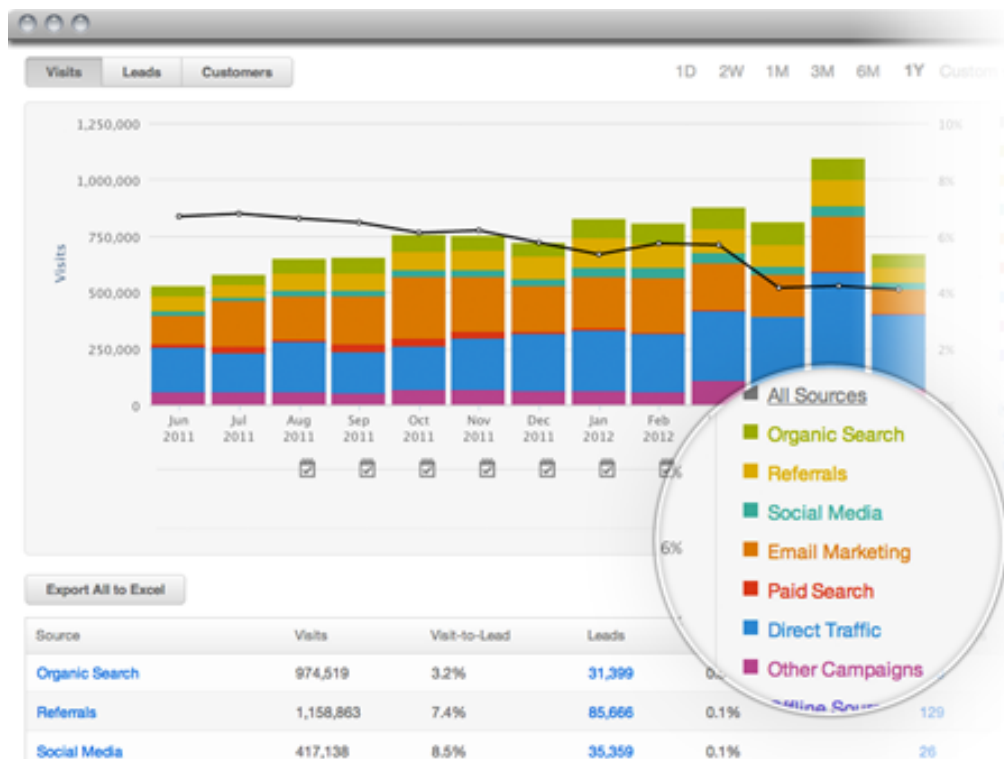
Measure Your Results

To find out if your blogging, SEO, social media, and lead nurturing is working, you need to track your results!

HubSpot's software has analytics which track how much traffic is going to your website, how many leads you are converting, how many customers you are gaining, and much more. This powerful data allows you to take a step back and analyze your Inbound Marketing plan. By using this data you can omit or revise current strategies to make sure you are running a fully optimized Inbound Marketing campaign.

Marketing Analytics

HubSpot allows anything that is measurable to be tracked, including traffic, social media clicks, leads, email click through rates, and much more. Be sure to use all of this information to better your plan and goals.



A/B Testing

A/B testing is a technique used to find ways to improve your marketing campaign. It allows you to test variations of landing pages, CTAs, and emails and will then tell you which performed better. The results compare the number of visits, click through rate, visit to submission rate, etc. A/B testing gives you the data needed to make educated decisions regarding different aspects of your website.

Closed Loop Reporting

Closed-Loop Reporting bridges the gap between sales and marketing making it an essential tool for any Inbound Marketing plan.

Closed-Loop Reporting provides information about where every lead came from, which content offer they downloaded and where they are in the sales funnel. You can then use this information to send targeted email campaigns to the lead, increasing your chances of making a sale. Knowing your buyer persona and what kind of content they prefer, you can effectively push them down the sales funnel.

Automated Reports

HubSpot allows you to receive weekly and monthly reports, through email, regarding results and analytics from your **Inbound Marketing campaign**. These reports include SEO summary, content summary, and a summary of your traffic and leads.

Chapter 8:

Where To Begin

Determine Resources Available

A successful **Inbound Marketing campaign** consists of **blogging**, **SEO**, **website design**, **email marketing**, **social media**, and lead nurturing. All of these components work together to create an effective **Inbound Marketing strategy**.

We understand that not every small business has the internal resources to staff and execute these components on a daily basis. If you feel overwhelmed by this task, there is always the option of considering an **inbound marketing agency** to help you with these components, start generating leads, and to do all of this at a low cost.

Be Committed

Inbound Marketing requires complete commitment, time, and effort. You have to dedicate ample time to blogging, posting and monitoring social media, generating leads, and nurturing leads. Without this commitment, you won't see results.

Ask for Help

We aren't trying to scare you off, but **Inbound Marketing** requires a lot of effort. Trust us, it is worth it when you start seeing results and generating customers!

Inbound Marketing can be a lot of work. If you agree that your company could benefit from Inbound Marketing but you don't think you are equipped with the staff or time to execute Inbound Marketing you may consider hiring an **Inbound Marketing Agency**.

- And as a matter of fact, you are in the right place! We can do all of this and more for your company, we can also provide custom reports to show you exactly how successful your marketing campaign is. Inbound Marketing is a proven strategy that allows small business owners like yourself to grow your business and turn your website into a valuable asset to your business.

Request An Inbound Marketting Assesment Today!

